before the idol of Ram Lalla. Another school friend weighed in. He felt bad, he said, about ‘Libtard Sikular Hindus who grew up hating their culture, history, roots and their identity. They have no ethics, grace, moral values to hold onto as they navigate life.’

Now, this WhatsApp group, with its 100-odd members, is not a scientific sample. But it is a microcosm of the wider social debate in middle India that Modi’s fronting of the Ram Temple construction unleashed, and a demonstration of the renewed potential of the Ayodhya movement as a political lightning rod.[2] Modi was hailed as the Hindu Hriday Samrat when he began his electoral career in Gujarat. Now, the carefully choreographed symbolism of the Vedic yajna in Ayodhya, with him as its karta (doer), subliminally posited Modi as a new Hindu suratrana (protector of the gods).[3]

Celebratory ‘Jai Sri Ram’ messages started pouring in on WhatsApp. The lonely liberal valiantly pushed back, saying that he actually taught yoga for a living and spent most of his time reading the Hindu scriptures. But the group admin moved in swiftly, unceremoniously removing him as well as the vociferous bhakts from the group. ‘Enough is enough,’ said the admin. ‘It’s a good day today.’ It was a revealing epitaph for a day that ended with most of my neighbours in the Noida high-rise apartment complex we live in lighting lamps outside their flats, like it was Diwali. On Zee News, meanwhile, the anchors, broadcasting from a faux Ram Temple set, had begun dancing to a Ram-dhun. Some of the studio guests were touching the feet of actors dressed up as Ram, Sita and Hanuman—specially brought on to the set—as is customary in many Ram Lilas, where the actors are said to embody the gods for the duration of the performance. It was that kind of day.

Modi’s yajna at Ayodhya can be directly contrasted with Nehru’s firm opposition to the state playing any role in reconstructing the Somnath temple in 1951. His intense debates with K.M. Munshi, the minister in his cabinet who spearheaded that initiative, and his insistence that Rajendra Prasad, India’s first president, attend the Somnath ceremony in his personal capacity, not as the Republic’s first citizen, set a template for a newly independent country that had just been partitioned on religious lines. Importantly, Nehru’s opposition to the government rebuilding temples was framed in a